



THE BULLPEN

By Lester Koelling

LES TROUBLED ABOUT TRIBE

HOLLYWOOD, Fla.—Along about this time every year I usually stick my neck out and say that Indianapolis has a darned good ball club, maybe a pennant contender.

Regretfully, I can't honestly say that this year. But it can be said that the club eventually will become better, perhaps before the season-opener next Tuesday.

To make it stronger, and a first-division occupant, it still needs an experienced catcher, a shortstop, another topflight pitcher and a right-handed power-hitting outfielder.

All of those voids are in the process of being filled. Until they are, the Indians will be represented by only 10 players with Triple A experience. The other 13 have never been above Double A and most of them no higher than A.

As they are now, the Indians are one of the biggest "if" squads ever to leave spring training. If their young pitchers come through, if Don Prohovich proves out at shortstop or third base, if Dick Means or Dick DiTusa can make the grade in the outfield, if John Romano's ailing arm heals, and if Jim Delsing can make a "comeback," then the Indians will be better off than they now appear.

Tribe president Ownie Bush, who left for Indianapolis today, and Chicago White Sox officials have been unrelenting in their efforts to acquire the necessary reinforcements. They have made many contacts. They have received many promises. But their pleading palms are still empty.

Obviously the clubs which have indicated assistance are waiting until the Monday cut-down date.

One or two of the players sought by Bush are involved in pending deals, and one catcher, John Bucha, already has been lost in that way.

Manager Andy Cohen is just as aware of the Indianapolis problems, but he is neither alarmed nor panicky. "We could develop into quite a ball club," says Cohen. "Other clubs in the league, I understand, are also waiting for help. There are only one or two clubs that appear to have a 'set' lineup."

"We've got some youngsters who have the potential," continued Andy, "and we owe it to them and to ourselves to give them a good shot. If we find that they can't make it, we'll just have to find someone who can."

Cohen's biggest worry, and problem, is the sore arm of Romano, one of the top prospects in the Chisox organization. No one seems able to diagnose the trouble. X-rays reveal nothing illuminating. Treatments have failed to ease the pain.

"Never in my managerial career have I run across anything like this," said Cohen. "Here's a boy who is considered the top prospect, who was to be our No. 1 catcher, and he comes up with a sore arm and no doctor has yet found the source or a reason. It beats me."

If Romano's arm remains sore, he will be left here for further disposition by the White Sox. In that event, Rookie Gene Martin from Waterloo will come north to spell Sam Hairston, who had been tagged as the No. 2 receiver. It is believed, however, that another catcher will be obtained before the Indians break camp.

The tentative squad which will go to Indianapolis, as announced last night by Manager Cohen, is the same, with one or two exceptions, as that which was predicted in The News last Monday. In addition to the aforementioned catchers, the squad, subject to last-minute changes, follows:

PITCHERS—Rodolfo Arias, Arnie Atkins, Charley Bicknell, Bill DuFour, Joe Dahlke, Barry Latman, Al Papai, Tony Ponce, Glen Rosenbaum, Don Rudolph, George Spencer and Ed Szyzewski.

INFIELDERS—Ron Jackson, Vince Garcia, Charley Williams, Don Prohovich and Gene Sheets, if a shortstop or third baseman isn't obtained before Saturday.

OUTFIELDERS—Ted Beard, Jim Delsing, Dick Means and Dick DiTusa.

The only unexpected selection is Szyzewski, the youngster who has been so impressive in exhibition games down here. He had been ticketed for Davenport in Class B, but Manager Cohen says "we're going to take him along, pitch him and give him a good chance to stay on the club."

The Chicago lad replaces Phil Brown, who was an earlier candidate to go North. Only 12 players will be on the plane that will arrive in Indianapolis early Sunday morning. The others have received permission to drive cars home or to pick up their families. Some left today, others are leaving tomorrow.

The Indians will not work out at Victory Field until Monday morning.

Severe rainstorms washed out yesterday's game with Buffalo at Pompano Beach and ruined Manager Cohen's plan to look at a few more hurlers, including Russ Heman. The latter was sent to Indianapolis by the White Sox, but is not believed ready for Triple A.

